

Usage Of Drones In The Israel and Palestine Conflict

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Drone warfare has become a much more common and prominent way of countries fighting in wars in the 20th and 21st centuries. It has especially become prominent in the 21st century with the Global War on Terror, which started in the early 2000s after 9/11. But, there have been many problems that many scholars and activists have had with the rise of drone warfare, such as how it has dehumanized war in some cases. The dehumanization that drones have caused has happened because there is “Physical distance between weapon and target [and] is linked to psychological detachment, resulting in the dehumanization of the enemy,” (Sharief 1) which has led to something called Gulf War syndrome in some cases. Gulf War syndrome has also been a result of the use of drone warfare and got its name from veterans experiencing PTSD, post-traumatic stress disorder, like symptoms even though they were drone operators and also effects about one third of the veterans from the Gulf War: “According to a report released by the Institute of Medicine (IOM) in 2013, about one-third of Gulf War veterans suffer from chronic multisymptom illness (CMI),” (Johns Hopkins), some other symptoms that some people have reported were “Fatigue, musculoskeletal pain, cognitive problems, skin rashes, and diarrhea,” (John Hopkins). Research from Johns Hopkins also claims that some cases of Gulf-War syndrome may be caused by chemical agents, such as pyridostigmine bromide, “...smoke from oil well fires, pesticides, depleted uranium or exposure to solvents and corrosive liquids, used during repair and maintenance,” (John Hopkins). However, in 2025 there are many conflicts that have been happening around the world that have been utilizing drone warfare and one of those conflicts being the Israel

and Palestine conflict that has been happening since the 19th century and has just recently been considered to be a genocide in late 2025 by the United Nations. According to the United Nations Israel has “...committed four of the five genocidal acts defined by the 1948 Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide, namely killing, causing serious bodily or mental harm, deliberately inflicting conditions of life calculated to bring about the destruction of the Palestinians in whole or in part, and imposing measures intended to prevent births,” (United Nations 2025), Israel has also stopped organizations, such as the Red Cross organization, from sending aid and supplies to ensure that citizens in Gaza get the aid and help they need. However, Israel on average has only allowed “...an average of only 459 trucks a day have entered Gaza between Oct. 12, when flow of the aid restarted, and Dec. 7, according to an AP analysis of figures by COGAT, the Israeli military body in charge of coordinating aid entry,” (Frankel 2025).

This conflict has recently been an important story in the news for a lot of reasons. Some of those reasons being the genocidal nature of the conflict and also how Israel has been using their drones against the people of Palestine. One of the ways they have been using drones is by bombing civilians, including children, “...to force them out of their homes or prevent them from returning to areas where Palestinians have been expelled...” (*Al Jazeera* 2025). This brings up many conflicts that go against a lot of general morals as well as human rights. Israel has also committed some war crimes doing so since they have been bombing schools and have not been giving adequate warning to civilians to seek shelter and instead bombing and killing many civilians to the point that it is considered a war crime: “By not issuing adequate warnings to civilians sheltering inside, these attacks caused extensive casualties, amounting to war crimes, including knowingly launching attacks that caused excessive and disproportionate civilian harm, and the crime against humanity of extermination,” (United Nations 2025). Even though Israel claims to give Palestinian citizens an “adequate warning” by using a technique called the knock-on-the-roof technique. The knock-on-the-roof technique is a technique where a

low-yield munition, which can be a small explosive charge with a localized blast radius, is then shot at the roof of a house, hence the name knock-on-the-roof. This technique has been used by Israel since the tactic was first reported in 2008 and was reported by journalists. The knock-on-the-roof technique is considered to not be an adequate warning for citizens by the United Nations because it constitutes a form of attack against citizens in the house that the technique was used against: “In a report published by the United Nations, Israel’s use of roof-knocking was harshly criticized, with investigators concluding that ‘roof knocks’ cannot be considered an effective warning given the confusion they often cause to building residents and the short time allowed to evacuate before the actual strike,” (United Nations 2015).

This is not the first instance that Israel has killed an extensive amount of people including children however. On July 22, 2002, Israeli forces sent an F-16 with a one ton bomb to assassinate the leader of Hamas, at the time Salah Shahadeh. In the process “The bomb destroyed the apartment building where Shehadeh lived and eight nearby buildings and partially destroyed nine others in the densely populated Gaza neighborhood of al-Daraj. In addition to Shehadeh and his guard, fourteen Palestinians, including eight children, were killed, and more than 150 people were injured,”(Hajjar 66). The killing of a leader of a terrorist organization may have been seen as a good thing to do, but the way that they carried out the operation was unethical and did a lot more harm to Palestine than it should have done. The drones that Israel have been using recently are from a Chinese company named Autel and they have been using their Evo drones which are used for photographers. But what Israel has been doing with these drones is attaching a hand grenade to them and dropping the grenades onto civilians and killing and injuring many civilians: “Soldiers are using mostly Evo drones produced by the Chinese company Autel, which are sold commercially for about \$3,000 and used by photographers...with a military-issued attachment known internally as an ‘iron ball’, a hand grenade can be affixed to the drone and dropped with the push of a button

to detonate on the ground,”” (Al Jazeera 2025). There are many such cases that Israel has been using these drones in Gaza to kill and injure people in order to either get rid of Palestinians or even remove them from their homes without adequate warning. This has helped the dehumanization of Palestinians and has not only been done by Israel however, western media has also been a main source of dehumanizing Palestinians since a lot of western media has been portraying Palestinians as “...inherently violent subhumans...” (Ibasis 2024) and has also been blaming Palestinian resistance forces for killing Israeli forces and has also been calling those resistance forces terrorist groups: “...not only helps Israel blame them for their own deaths but also frame the armed resistance against its occupation and apartheid as ‘terrorism’,” (Ibasis 2024). President Donald Trump, during the 2024 election, called Joe Biden a “‘a very bad Palestinian’ who doesn’t want to help Israel ‘finish the job’ against Hamas in its war on Gaza,” (Al Jazeera 2024). This insult is used as a way to diminish Joe Biden and his presidency but it was also used as a way to dehumanize Palestinians and classify all Palestinian citizens as “bad” people. The media has also been used as a tool in order to help the dehumanization of Palestinians in order to get more people on the side of Israel and the IDF such as drones are used to dehumanize the citizens of Palestine. This goes to show that drones have not been the only way that Israel has been dehumanizing the Palestinian citizens.

There are however some non-state actors that have been using drones and some have been labeled as VNSA’s (violent non-state actors) by the United States government, such as terrorist groups like the Houthis and Hezbollah where they would use drones by kamikaze them into a specific target: “VNSAs such as the Houthis and Hezbollah have conducted attacks using kamikaze drones loaded with munitions, flying directly into the specified target,” (Dulligan 2025). This can be a very very dangerous way of using these drones because they can cause so much damage and destruction if they were to attach a bomb or even a grenade to the drones. However, VNSA’s have been using drones in this manner for a while now. There was a study that was conducted that revealed that there has been about

1,122 incidents between 2006-2023 that have used armed UAVs and were done by terrorist groups with about 91.3% of those attacks happening after 2016 in the Middle-east and Africa: “In an open-source study on the use of armed UAVs by non-state actors conducted by Håvard Haugstvedt, 1,122 incidents were recorded from 2006-2023. During this time, 91.3 percent of all attacks occurred in the Middle East and North Africa, with 1,109 out of the 1,122 occurring after 2016,” (Dulligan 2025).

After doing some research and thinking, I believe that the usage of drones in warfare is a less ethical way of fighting than it would be to have human soldiers fight. Human soldiers I believe is a better and more ethical way of fighting in wars because even though both sides may lose a lot of men by using human soldiers, it humanizes the other side of who they are fighting compared to using drones where it pretty much detaches you from who you are harming or killing. The usage of drones also can cause the people operating the drones to develop Gulf-War syndrome which can last for at least 30 years and give those operators PTSD especially. Also with the development of unmanned and manned drones in modern warfare, Gulf-War syndrome can become more and more prevalent in the people who operate the drones due to more usage of drones in warfare. The usage of drones also affects the victims who are not necessarily the target of a drone attack because many drone operators in some countries, such as Israel, are sometimes told that civilian casualties may either be ok or necessary which can be seen as dehumanizing civilians using the drones. So I believe that the more “morally good” choice or “more ethical” choice would be to use human soldiers during any kind of warfare rather than using drones unless there is a situation that drones are essential for carrying out a mission.

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